

HISTORY, REWRITTEN IN A STUMBLE

Long-distance runner **Sawan Barwal** scripted history by breaking the 48-year-old marathon national record, the longest-standing mark in Indian athletics.

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With 100 metres to go at the Rotterdam Marathon on a Sunday morning, Sawan Barwal could see the digital clock atop the finishing gate. The display flashed 2:09:50. In that moment, Sawan later recalled, he felt a harder push might have taken him just over two hours and 10 minutes. He knew that would be more than enough to create history. The Indian marathon record of 2:12:00, set by Shivnath Singh in 1978, had stood untouched for nearly half a century. Sawan looked set to smash that mark.

The 28-year-old, who until last year specialised in the 5000m and 10000m and had not won an international medal over those distances, did not appear under strain for most of his first marathon.

He had been on pace for a 2:09:14 finish at the 35 km mark, usually when inexperienced runners begin to feel the full weight of the distance. Although a sudden gust of wind and drop in temperature slowed him slightly, he remained on course for a record.

Then, with the finish line in sight, his body gave way. Sawan blacked out, stumbled and collapsed on the road. He picked himself up slowly, only to fall again, as the seconds slipped away.

A race volunteer ran up to him and helped him onto his unsteady feet. Sawan staggered towards the finish line.

"Until the last 100 metres, he was averaging three

minutes and four seconds for every kilometre. That last 100 metres took him a minute and a half. He was almost walking at that point," his coach, Ajith Markose, who was watching helplessly from the sidelines, told this publication.

Sawan ultimately crossed the finish line in 2:11:58. It was enough to break the oldest record in Indian athletics, even if only by two seconds.

When Sportstar reached out to Sawan after the race, the final minutes were a blur. A couple of days later, as he recovered at home in Bengaluru, he recounted a finish that felt cinematic.

"My goal before the races was to finish in the 2:08 to 2:10 range. At the 40km mark, I looked at my watch and roughly estimated that I would finish at about 2:10. However, the section of the race after the 35km mark took me through a forest on the outskirts of the city, and a very cold wind suddenly appeared. I had put some water on my head, and it began to freeze, causing me to start feeling a bit dizzy. When I had about 100m to go, I stumbled and fell once but caught myself off the boards on the side of the road. I pushed myself again, and then I remember looking